

SUFISM AS WORLD LITERATURE Spring 2025

INSTRUCTOR: EMAN MORSI

OFFICE: 208 REED HALL

CLASS TIMES: 10A

CLASS LOCATION: 101 THORNTON HALL

OFFICE HOURS: 2:00 PM – 4:00 PM



COURSE DESCRIPTION AND OBJECTIVES:

In his book, *What is World Literature?*, David Damroch argues that world literature is not a canon of texts but rather a mode of circulation and reading that gains in translation. Sufism, often referred to in English as “Islamic mysticism”, has long appealed to many literary traditions and informed multiple aesthetic projects around the globe—evolving in significance as it circulated through translation. This course offers an introduction to Sufism *as* world literature. It explores its universal appeal (in such languages as Arabic, English, Persian, Spanish, Turkish, Urdu etc.) and its many aesthetic manifestations and transformations around the world. In addition to the thematic, the course offers an extensive and diverse (but not exhaustive) survey of Sufism’s impact on literary genres.

Some of the questions we will ask in this course include: what happens to Sufi concepts when they cross linguistic borders? Can we speak of multiple literary Sufisms? What about Sufism appealed to various authors? How did authors incorporate Sufi elements into their craft? What kind of worldview did it help them develop? How did literary adaptations of Sufism map over already-existing local mystical and aesthetic traditions?

Advanced reading ability in a second language is preferred but not required as all class materials are available in English.

GRADE DISTRIBUTION:

- Class Participation 10%
- Presentation 14%
- Weekly Assessments 36%
- Creative Project OR Close Reading 15%
- Research paper 25%

Attendance and Participation:

- Regular attendance, and participation in class discussions are required. More than 2 unexcused absences will result in the deduction of a half grade point at the end of the term.
- If you need special accommodations due to sickness, religious holidays, or family/personal matters, please reach out to me (your instructor) as soon as possible.
- Students will receive 1 point for participation in class discussion per week.

Presentations:

- Each student will be responsible for one presentation during the term. The presentation should be around 15 minutes long and should focus on one of the primary sources assigned that week.
- To receive the full grade for this assignment, students must:
 - Present their own analysis of the primary text,
 - Present their own research on the author,
 - Engage critically with the secondary materials provided for that week,
 - Pose several questions to their classmates that would help them initiate a discussion.

Weekly Assessment:

- To be uploaded to Canvas by Sunday at 11:59pm EST.
- A form will be provided with prompts to assess the materials assigned.

Close Reading Analysis

- A literary analysis of roughly 1000 words should be submitted by end of **week 5**.
- The analysis should be primarily based on your own in-depth close reading of a work of your choice by one of the authors read in the first five weeks of the term.
- A detailed prompt will be uploaded on Week 4

Creative Project

- Channel the pre-modern authors you read to create your own, contemporary creative writing.
- A detailed prompt will be uploaded on Week 4

Final Research Paper:

- For the final research paper, students will need to analyze the work of a 20th or 21st century author not studied in this course. A list of potential authors to choose from will be provided on Canvas. That said, students are encouraged to research other authors including ones from literary traditions not covered in this course (e.g. Chinese, Russian, Wolof, Swahili etc).
- A strong research paper will draw on in-class discussions of the many concepts of Sufism and aesthetic worldmaking.
- Students should adhere to the following timeline when working on their final paper:
 - a. Week 6: Research contemporary authors, pick an author.
 - b. Week 7: Create and submit a bibliography of readings and other resources you are considering using for your research paper. Schedule an office hour meeting with the professor to discuss your bibliography.
 - c. Week 8: Meet with professor to share an outline of the research paper
 - d. Week 9: Complete first draft and meet with professor to discuss it.
 - e. Submission: The final research paper is due a week from the last day of classes.

Texts and Resources:

Please buy, rent, or borrow: Doris Lessing, *The Memoirs of a Survivor*.

All other materials for this class will be available on Canvas.

DARTMOUTH POLICIES & STATEMENTS**Academic Integrity**

Fundamental to the principle of independent learning are the requirements of honesty and integrity in the performance of academic assignments, both in and out of the classroom. Dartmouth operates on the principle of academic honor, without proctoring of examinations. Any student who submits work which is not his or her own, or commits other acts of academic dishonesty, violates the purposes of the college and is subject to disciplinary actions, up to and including suspension or separation.

For more information on Academic Honor please consult the following site:

<https://students.dartmouth.edu/community-standards/policy/academic-honor-principle>

Religious Observances

Some students may wish to take part in religious observances that occur during this academic term. If you have a religious observance that conflicts with your participation in the course, please meet with me before the end of the second week of the term to discuss appropriate accommodations.

Student Accessibility and Accommodations

Students requesting disability-related accommodations and services for this course are required to register with Student Accessibility Services (SAS; [Getting Started with SAS webpage](#); student.accessibility.services@dartmouth.edu; 1-603-646-9900) and to request that an accommodation email be sent to me in advance of the need for an accommodation. Then, students should schedule a follow-up meeting with me to determine relevant details such as what role SAS or its [Testing Center](#) may play in accommodation implementation. This process works best for everyone when completed as early in the quarter as possible. If students have questions about whether they are eligible for accommodations or have concerns about the implementation of their accommodations, they should contact the SAS office. All inquiries and discussions will remain confidential.

Mental Health and Wellness

The academic environment is challenging, our terms are intensive, and classes are not the only demanding part of your life. There are a number of resources available to you on campus to support your wellness, including: the [Counseling Center](#) which allows you to book triage appointments online, the [Student Wellness Center](#) which offers wellness check-ins, and your [undergraduate dean](#). The student-led [Dartmouth Student Mental Health Union](#) and their peer support program may be helpful if you would like to speak to a trained fellow student support listener. If you need immediate assistance, please contact the counselor on-call at (603) 646-9442 at any time. Please make me aware of anything that will hinder your success in this course.

CLASS SCHEDULE

Please note that:

- a) Readings are subject to change based on the needs and pace of the class,
 b) In addition to the primary and secondary readings listed in this syllabus, supplementary readings to fill knowledge gaps or support student queries will be added to Canvas throughout the term.
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Introduction to Sufism

Week One: The Basics

- David Damroch, *What is World Literature?* (Introduction)
- Lloyd Ridgeon (Ed). *The Cambridge Companion to Sufism*. Chapters 1-4.
- Bā‘ūnīyah, ‘Ā’ishah bint Yūsuf. *The Principles of Sufism*. Trans. Th. Emil Homerin. (Repentance, Sincerity, Remembrance)

Week Two: Sufism and the Poetic

Primary:

- Bā‘ūnīyah, ‘Ā’ishah bint Yūsuf. *The Principles of Sufism*. Trans. Th. Emil Homerin. (Love)
- Rabi’a al-Adawiyah, *selected poems*. (Original in Arabic)
- Charles Upton, *Doorkeeper of the Heart: Versions of Rabi’a* (Excerpts of anecdotes and sayings)

Secondary:

- David Damroch, *What is World Literature?* (Chapter 1)
- Widad El Sakkakini, *First among Sufis: The Life and Thought of Rabia Al-Adawiyya the Woman Saint of Basra*. (Excerpts)
- Rkia Elaroui Cornell, *Rabi’a from Narrative to Myth: The Many Faces of Islam’s Most Famous Woman Saint, Rabi’a Al-Adawiyya*. (Excerpts)

Discussion key concepts: the self, love/passion, the path, the divine.

Supplementary readings on Canvas

Sufi aesthetics in the Pre-Modern World

Week 3: Sufism and the Couplet

Primary

- Jalal al-Din Rumi, *Masnavi-ye-Ma’navi (The Spiritual Couplets)* (Original in Persian)

Secondary:

- Husayn Ilahi-Ghomshei, “The Symphony of Rumi” in *The Philosophy of Ecstasy: Rumi and the Sufi Tradition* by Leonard Lewisohn (ed).
- Leonard Lewisohn, “Principles of the Philosophy of Ecstasy in Rumi’s Poetry” in *The Philosophy of Ecstasy: Rumi and the Sufi Tradition* by Leonard Lewisohn (ed).

Discussion main point: The masnavi/mathnawi couplet as building block of medieval poetic traditions in Arabic, Persian, Turkish, Urdu.

Sufi key concepts: love, reason, the mirror

Supplementary readings on Canvas

Week 4: Sufism and the Parable*Primary*

- Sheikh Farīd-Ud-Dīn Attar, *The Conference of the Birds* (Original in Persian)

Secondary

- *Symbolic Dance: The Conference of Birds* produced & directed by Linda Lewett

Discussion main points: Parables, allegories, and fables as central to medieval story telling structures.

Key concepts: the garden, the sublime, infinity, anthropomorphism, the symbiocene, and equilibrium.

Supplementary readings on Canvas

Week 5: Sufism and the Epic*Primary:*

- Qutban Suhrawardi, *Mirigāvatī (The Magic Doe)* (Original in Urdu-Hindi)

Secondary:

- Nashir Naqvi and Dhanwant Kaur, *Sufism and Indian Heritage* (excerpts)

Main discussion points: Sufi and Hindu influences on the Hindavi Epic tradition.

Supplementary readings on Canvas

Sufism in Modern Literary Projects**Week 6: Sufism and Gnosis***Primary*

- Jorge Luis Borges: “The Zahir” and “The Aleph” (Original in Spanish)

Secondary:

- Jorge Luis Borges, *Borges on Writing* (Excerpts)
- *Variaciones Borges* (select pieces from journal)

Genre: the short story.

Concepts: the mirror, infinity, reason, equilibrium

Supplementary readings on Canvas.

Week 7: Sufism and Feminism*Primary*

- Doris Lessing, *The Memoirs of a Survivor* (Original in English)

Secondary:

- Doris Lessing, “[Sufism, A way of Seeing](#)”, Washington Post, 1982.
- Shadia Fahim, *Doris Lessing: Sufi Equilibrium and the Form of the Novel* (Introduction and Chapter 3)

Genre discussion: feminist speculative fiction and the novel.

Keywords: embodiment, knowledge, women and sainthood, Women Sufis of the past and present, the patriarchy and the publishing world.

Supplementary readings on Canvas.

Week 8: Sufism and Communism*Primary:*

- Nazim Hikmet, poetry selection (Original in Turkish)

Secondary:

- Talât Sait Halman and Jayne L. Warner. “Nazım Hikmet: lyricist as iconoclast” in *Rapture and Revolution: Essays on Turkish Literature*.

Genre discussion: modernist poetry of the early-mid 20th century.

Keywords: Romantic Revolutionaries, being, belonging, lyricism.

Supplementary readings on Canvas.

Week 9: Sufism and Heterodoxy*Primary:*

- José Ángel Valente, poetry selection (Original in Spanish)

Secondary:

- Andrew Debicki. “José Ángel Valente: Reading and Rereading,” in *Poetry of Discovery: The Spanish Generation of 1956-1971*.
- Jonathan Mayhew, “El signo de la feminidad”: Gender and poetic creation in José Ángel Valente. *Revista De Estudios Hispánicos*, 25(2), 123.
- Rodríguez Fer Claudio. “Faces of the Infinite: Neoplatonism and Poetry at the Confluence of Africa Asia and Europe.” in *Eroticism of the Infinite: Neoplatonism Kabbalism and Sufism in the Work of José Ángel Valente*.

Key discussion concepts: meaning and transcendence, universality, the mirror of the self, metaphysical space.

Supplementary readings on Canvas

OR

Week 9: Sufism and Existentialism*Primary:*

- Tawfiq al-Hakim, *Shahrazad* (Original in Arabic)

Secondary:

- Jeries Khoury, “Hakim’s Equilibrium under a Microscope: A Study in al-Hakim’s Philosophy through his Plays”
- *The Arabian Nights* (Excerpts: frame story, first night and end of the English volume)

Genre discussion: 20th century “theatre of the mind”.

Key discussion concepts: understanding vs knowing, mirror of the self, on being.

Supplementary readings on Canvas

Week 10: Conclusion

- David Damroch, *What is World Literature?* (Conclusion)